

# Why do we do Science?

Just one answer: For the betterment of society.

Two aspects of that:

- 1 To increase the material quality of life: from the elimination of poverty and having clean drinking water, to having nicer racing yachts.
- 2 Increasing the non-material quality of life: intellectual and aesthetic pleasures, the quest to understand the universe and the planet on which we live. The human adventure.
  - ▶ Mathematics is not important because it enables us to build machines. Machines are important because they give us more time for mathematics.  
Henri Poincaré, *Science and Method*, 1908.

But note: federal funding comes mainly for task one!

Also, personal motivation can be different from societal motivation, and may be purely aesthetic.